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Bilingual Development in the Tai-Vietnamese Multicultural Borderland

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ABSTRACT

Northern Vietnam, in particular the regions along the international border, is home to a rich diversity of language communities. Important research opportunities have presented themselves in the Tai-speaking communities in rural districts near Laos with an emphasis on the development and preservation of the Tai languages. One opportunity in particular focuses on the new generation of bilingual school-age children. Preliminary results of the present study regarding the sociolinguistic setting are reported to better understand the language use context of community bilingualism. The method applied for this exploratory survey included different components, each one gathering different kinds of data: interviews with parents of elementary school students and their teachers, in-depth discussions with local language scholars, a study of the previous research on language and literacy in the Tai languages of the region, and assessment of the bilingual ability of the 6-year-old population of a village known for its conservation of the local variant of the language. Findings confirmed that the local community language has been preserved in the child population. At the same time, assessment data point to the rapidly growing influence of the Vietnamese language in every domain of village life, including at home. Overall results of the study place the finding of language preservation in the context of modern-day regional interrelation and historical connection. The concluding discussion of results presents a hypothesis that these tentatively observed favorable conditions might represent a distinctive case.

Resumen

El norte de Vietnam, en particular las regiones a lo largo de la frontera internacional, alberga una rica diversidad de comunidades lingüísticas. Se han presentado importantes oportunidades de investigación en las comunidades de habla tai en los distritos rurales cercanos a Laos, con énfasis en el desarrollo y la preservación de las lenguas tai. Una oportunidad en particular se centra en la nueva generación de niños bilingües en edad escolar. Presentamos los resultados preliminares de un estudio sobre el entorno sociolingüístico para entender mejor el contexto de uso de la lengua en el bilingüismo comunitario. El método aplicado para el estudio exploratorio consiste en diferentes componentes, cada uno de los cuales reúne diferentes tipos de datos: entrevistas con padres de familia en la escuela primaria y los maestros, discusiones en profundidad con investigadores locales de la lengua, el estudio de investigaciones previas sobre lengua y alfabetización en las lenguas tai de la región y la evaluación de las habilidades bilingües de la población de seis años de un pueblo conocido por la conservación de la variante local de la lengua. Los resultados confirmaron que, de hecho, la lengua de la comunidad local se ha conservado en la población infantil. Al mismo tiempo, los

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datos de la evaluación apuntan a una tendencia de rápida expansión por parte del idioma vietnamita en todos los ámbitos de la vida rural, incluido el hogar. Los resultados generales del estudio sitúan la preservación de la lengua en el contexto de una interrelación regional y una conexión vital con la herencia literaria. La reflexión final sobre los resultados presenta la hipótesis de que estas condiciones favorables, observadas provisionalmente, pueden representar un caso excepcional.

1 | Introduction

Following the national/official language, spoken natively by over 85% of the population, the Tai language communities of Vietnam, taken as a whole, represent the largest linguistic group in the country.¹ In the province of Thanh Hóa, the site of the current phase of the fieldwork study, communities are also located in close proximity to speakers of the language in Laos. In this northern region, including the other border provinces, there appears to have developed over the years a notable level of awareness of the relationship with the other Tai-speaking communities. This awareness appears to be tied to a deliberate orientation toward preserving the Tai languages. It is expressed among teachers who are bilingual and who work on the implementation of a school curriculum in Tai and Vietnamese, and local scholars who conduct research on the language and writing system as part of a community-supported effort to recover and study historical documents. The two research questions of the current study point to the need to gain a better understanding of:

- the sociolinguistic context of bilingualism as revealed in actual performance on language tasks. The focus here is mainly on the interaction between the local Thái language and Vietnamese among children, and if there is a tendency toward preserving Thái.² In the field of applied linguistics, this kind of interaction would be described as a balanced bilingual ability. Readers are referred to the current research on the relevant cognitive foundations in this domain (Grosjean 2022; Meisel 2021). Assessment of child bilingual ability will provide information from direct measurement about this possible tendency; for discussion, see Nguyễn et al. (2023) and Ogilvie (2011).
- the awareness in the local community of the linguistic and cultural relationship with other Tai-speaking communities of the region. These ties are related to the historical inheritance of language and literary culture that they all share. Has access to the literary heritage associated with the local Thái language and culture continued to trend toward continuity and conservation?

Starting with the second point (awareness of the cultural and linguistic heritage), this factor is closely related to the contact over the many centuries with the languages and cultures of China and Vietnam (Kelley 2013; Pittayaporn 2014; Tai 2005). Thanh Hóa and its neighboring provinces can be characterized as multilingual dating from ancient times, with extensive language contact today encompassing the national language and the local languages.

The current study is located in one of the most linguistically diverse districts of the border region, Bá Thước (see Figure 1). The study compares one town that is majority Vietnamese-

speaking (Cánh Nang) with the language learning situation of a predominantly Thái-speaking village (Cổ Lũng). Recent census estimates from the two communities document this contrast, reflecting the overall profile of the province. Aside from the observation of favorable objective conditions for Thái language preservation, there exists an active study group of Thái language scholars centrally located in the district. The project was given the opportunity to work closely with these local researchers who also are secondary school teachers.

Based on tentative findings of fieldwork, consisting of interviews with local families, including children, educators, and language and literary preservation scholars who work on the recovery of historical Tai-language documents, the present study outlines an initial working framework for ongoing research. Part of the explanation for the emergence of these local initiatives may lie in the access, by communities, to different kinds of *relationship* and *continuity*, for example: (1) the *linkages and relationships* within the Tai language family that appear to be maintained across provinces and regionally in Southeast Asia more broadly, and (2) cultural knowledge of different kinds that traces ties back in history—a *continuity of preserved artistic and literary heritage*. Evidence for a potentially favorable context for language development in Thái and Vietnamese is presented from the results of an assessment program involving 47 first-grade students from the Bá Thước district and extensive interviews with adult speakers of Thái locally.

2 | Method

As mentioned above, this first summary of fieldwork findings is required to provide the project with relevant context for studying bilingual development among child language learners. Fieldwork was framed by an extended interview with Hà Nam Ninh, a nationally renowned scholar of the Tai languages of northern Vietnam and resident in the Bá Thước district, on topics of language and culture. Discussions focused on the two research questions of the study: the present-day tendencies of child bilingual development and the broader cultural context of Thái language interaction with Vietnamese locally. What are the trends in Thái language preservation in the child population and what can be ascertained regarding the level of awareness of, and engagement with, the Thái language literary heritage in the community as a whole? This heritage is highly regarded throughout the region as a cultural resource that has been preserved even as the use of the national language has expanded to every previously remote locality. Local scholars continue the work of documentation of historical documents because of the relevance of these materials for modern-day Thái language and literary preservation. The materials feature the historical documents, in traditional script, and by extension include the surviving genres of the Thái oral tradition.

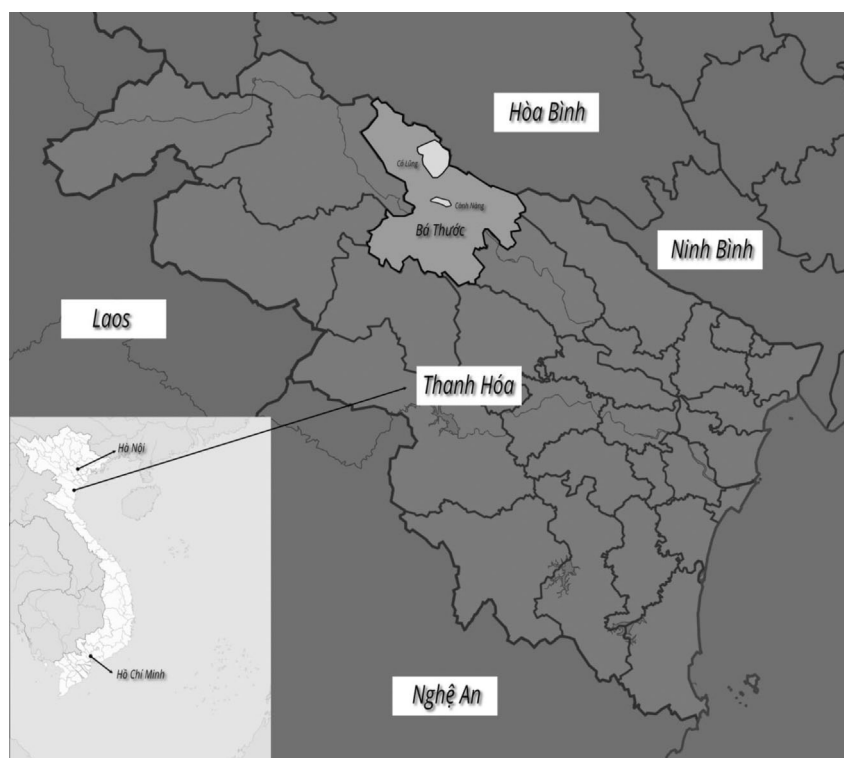


FIGURE 1 | Map of Cánh Nàng and Cổ Lũng in Bá Thước District

The present account serves in part as a follow-up discussion to the interview granted in 2015 by Hà Nam Ninh to Professor Acharya Choowonglert (2022). The 2022 paper is pertinent to our study as it addressed a similar theme of linguistic and cultural relationships among the Tai language communities of the region in the face of the significant expansion of the Vietnamese language. On the theme of continuity, the author's account coincides with our observations and interview results regarding the ethnolinguistic vitality of the Thái language of Thanh Hóa, specifically in the work of documentation of historic documents and the study of the literary heritage by local bilingual educators.

The 2024 follow-up interview with Hà Nam Ninh (of the present study) consisted of approximately 19 h of discussion, a portion of which was accompanied by attending assistants, members of the local research collective, that for expository convenience we can call the Bá Thước Literary Study Group. To corroborate the examples and observations discussed, separate interviews were secured with teachers, school principals, and parents, and a language assessment was conducted with children.

The child data were primarily in the form of results from a formal assessment of language ability. As bilingual speakers, the first-grade children were evaluated in both languages that they speak. The parent interviews, prior to the child bilingual assessment, confirmed informal reports that their sons and daughters were speakers of Thái and Vietnamese, in all cases. See Table 1 for an overview of interviews and assessments. The question that the actual assessment would perhaps answer was if comprehension and speaking ability were *comparable* in the two languages or if there was an *imbalance* in ability, with one language becoming stronger than the other.

3 | Context of the Study of Bilingualism in School

3.1 | Cultural Diversity and Variation in Contexts of Language Contact

For the purposes of this study, it will be useful to introduce three terms that refer to differentiation within a branch, family, division, or other type of grouping of related languages (as a working proposal for the present study). The three-part profile is adapted from Diller's (1998) presentation on the "Tai language family and the comparative method":

- *variant*—generic category based on a set of shared linguistic features that identifies a language variety, toplect (or simply "lect"), grouping of native tongues, etc.
- *dialect*—in comparing two or more close variants that over space and time have not diverged significantly such that speakers of each dialect, that forms part of the same language, understand each other (mutual comprehension, intercommunication). An example is the dialectal variation within the Vietnamese language.
- *language*—comparing two variants that belong to the same language family or branch, for example, that over time have come to drift apart to the point where mutual comprehension, and intercommunication (in speech) are no longer possible.

For the Tai languages of East and Southeast Asia, these distinctions are especially useful. For example, the difference between Southern Zhuang (Guanxi province in China and northern Vietnam) and the variants (the national standard and locally adjacent dialects) spoken in Thailand is a difference of *languages*,

TABLE 1 | Overview of interviews and assessments.

<i>Structured formal interviews:</i> Parents of the children who sat for the language assessment. Answers to four questions provided information on the languages that children know, which language children use when speaking to different persons at home and outside the home, and which language adults typically speak at home.
<i>Structured formal language assessment of bilingual ability:</i> Six-year-old children enrolled in first grade. Parallel versions in Thái and Vietnamese (Chicken story—Thái; Dog story—Vietnamese); 16 questions each, plus free narration.
<i>Open-ended interviews:</i> Teachers and directors, mainly at the Cổ Lũng elementary school. The topic of informal discussion: language policy in preschool and first grade, customary language use by families with young children prior to preschool, and language use policy and typical practice in the higher grades after 5th grade.

belonging to the same family or the same branch, but linguistically distant. In between, so to speak, it is also clear that there are many intermediate examples where the difference between dialect and language is one of degrees or cultural difference reflected in vocabulary. Variation also depends on the extent of contact over time with other Asian languages, most notably Vietnamese and Chinese (Enfield and Evans 2000; Pittayaporn 2014). An example (from outside of the Tai family) is the relationship between the Vietnamese and Muong languages: monolingual speakers of one sometimes make the observation they are able to count on partial comprehension of the other depending on the context and topic of conversation.

Because of the great diversity of the family, forged over thousands of years of migration and close interaction with other populations, also of great complexity (Alves 2017; Suriya 2007; Tran 2019), the ongoing linguistic contact between two different Tai languages or dialects results in different kinds of mutual influence. Researchers, for example, have studied the different types of switching and borrowing, and even shifting of actual underlying competence, in particular among the younger generations (Dechapraturmwan 2016; Tayiasanant 2015). In these cases, the factors of linguistic and cultural proximity perhaps play an important role, affecting language change over time in different ways. What might be the result of contact between two variants of Tai that are proximate, linguistically, and geographically adjacent, in comparison to a situation of contact between two variants that are more distant and separated by geography? The former could be an example of contact between dialectal variants in relation to each other and the latter between two separate languages of the same Tai family. Within the same region, for example, Thanh Hóa and neighboring provinces of Sơn La, Hòa Bình, Ninh Bình, and Nghệ An, mutual inter-communication varies among speakers of Tai. This topic is related to the question of designing a script for written communication, to be discussed in the following section.

3.2 | Writing System and Script

In two middle schools of the district, students study the Tai script (of Vietnam: “Tai-Viet”) as part of an experimental bilingual education program: Trường Phổ thông Dân tộc Nội trú THCS Bá Thước and Trường Phổ thông Dân tộc Nội trú THCS Thường Xuân. Extensive discussions during interviews focused special attention on the writing system question that extends beyond the school and the literacy learning curriculum to debates among language promoters, specialists, and scholars. There exist differences of opinion on how to solve the problem of designing a

script, or scripts, that can serve the wide-ranging variation among the different variants of Tai in the region. Here, it is important to point out that this discussion is similar to the discussion in many other multilingual regions around the world, in relation to the concepts of bigraphia and multigraphia.

Writing in the Chinese language is an example of one type of bigraphia (morphosyllabic *hanzi* and alphabetic *pinyin*). Another example of a non-conflictive system is the integration, for the Japanese language, of *kanji*, two *kana* scripts, and *the romanization of Japanese*. Writing in Serbo-Croatian is an example of a different type of bigraphia that in the past has been associated with conflict. A similar relationship of conflict often marked the relationship in Vietnam between standard *hanzi* writing and the vernacular adaptation of the Chinese characters of the *chữ nôm* script (Nguyễn 1992).

Historically, and in regard to its design features, parallel to the Vietnamese-language adaptation of the Chinese characters, the Zhang morphosyllabic character script for the Tai variant of Guanxi province is still in use largely among priests and traditional poets and narrators (see Supporting Information 1). It is also found in over 85 historical literary works in circulation within communities. There is even evidence that this character script, *chữ nôm Tay*, had been taught in local schools during the 1900s (Holm 2020). The traditional Zhang character script has also been the medium for writing down folk songs, poetry, narrative, and personal communication (Tai 2005). As such, the example of a relatively widely used Tai-language script, of local origin, serving over the years as a resource for the preservation of literary and artistic heritage in the China-neighboring regions of Vietnam, does not go unnoticed by scholars working in the same realms of language and literature in the Laotian-neighboring Tai-speaking regions. An officially sponsored alphabetic script, introduced during the 1950s, in China, is learned by speakers of the Tai language in the general population. See Ta and Ta (2020) and Supporting Information 1 for an example of the use of alphabetic script for Tai in Vietnam.

It is only natural that a certain degree of variation characterizes writing in an internally diverse population of speakers. In each local bilingual community, interaction occurs among speakers of *different dialects* of the same Tai language and *different Tai languages* of the larger branch and family. Thus, the reasons for the variation in the Tai-Viet orthography from one community to another are often complex and do not necessarily imply conflict or even controversy (Vitrano-Wilson 2018). In some cases, dialectal variation will be reflected in the orthography and other cases

not. The communities of the different related variants of Tai are distributed widely from Sơn La Province to Nghệ An.

Writing in the Tai languages is notable for the variation across both the writing system *and* script (variation with a writing system). In Guangxi (China) and Cao Bằng, Lạng Sơn, and Bắc Kạn (Vietnam) provinces, the language is written in traditional morphosyllabic characters and (in different contexts) alphabetically. In the regions of north-western Vietnam, the variation appears among scripts derived from the traditional Brahmic abugida system (that is official in Laos and Thailand).

Uses and applications of the derived scripts are the subject of lively discussion among language and literacy scholars; for a historical perspective, see Phan (2010) and Yukti (2012). One apparent difference regarding proposals for script adoption makes reference to the alternatives:

- the promotion of an orthographic standard for Tai readers and writers located in the region encompassing the many districts in the region near the border with Laos—to make uniform the script conventions for the different linguistic variants, versus
- the preservation of orthographic distinctions corresponding to the different variants. According to Yukti (2011), seven distinct Tai scripts are in use today in the region of Thanh Hóa, Sơn La, Hòa Bình, and Yên Bái, as the different scripts, corresponding to each variant, have been passed down over the years.

The qualification, above, of “apparent difference” follows from the suggestion in the exchange of views that the two viewpoints may not be actually in opposition in regard to language policy implementation in practice, or even at the level of concept, in theory.

A related research question is that of the degree of actual linguistic distance among variants, ranging from:

- (in Vietnam) relatively close or distant, but generally close enough for conversation (Cầm 2003), and for other uses of language, to
- the variants being often or typically distant and mutually unintelligible to a large degree.

One argument in favor of *script* standardization would point out that the unification of orthography does not in any way imply linguistic convergence or unification of dialects/variants, in speech. Spelling patterns could even vary from one speech community to another while using a unified set of graphemes. A second related question (of more practical application) might present itself in the work of linguists and information technology specialists who collaborate on the digitization of the Tai script. What degree of variation or irregularity can be sustained when designing software for word processing? In this regard, there are different purposes or uses of word processing, for example, for communication among individuals or use of writing for communication on the internet.

In the end, as Vitrano-Wilson (2018) suggests, cultural, sociolinguistic, and historical reasons in some contexts come to be more prominent and in other contexts less so, motivations shifting over time and depending on circumstances of different kinds. From this point of view, coexistence in the use of parallel scripts, and even a high degree of variation, presents itself as a viable alternative. The same approach can apply to problems of standardization in general.

3.3 | The Literary Heritage

This section briefly summarizes the main aspect of the *continuity* factor in regard to art and literature mentioned in Section 1: (1) continuity of cultural knowledge that traces ties back in history to a preserved artistic and literary heritage. This factor might explain in part the emergence of active local initiatives by scholars and teachers centered on the study of Tai language and culture, especially in its literature.

Conserved in traditional Tai Dam script, both prosaic chronicles and narrative poems (as long as 2000 verse lines) are performed in the modern day. Poetic form, as in recitation (poem singing), is tied to musical form, defining melody (Cầm 2007). Epic chronicles, the creation myth, and accounts of community/ethnic origin included, for example, in the *Kwan To Muang* [*Stories of the Country*] are associated with specific locations in the Tai language-speaking region, delineating the boundary of the historical homeland. Here, one of the important contexts of performance appears in the funeral ceremony (Yukti 2014).

The narrative poem, or verse novel, is one of the venerated genres not only of Tai-Vietnamese literature (Lê 2019) but of the national literary tradition. Of the most prominent and perhaps distinctive categories of poetic expression studied in fieldwork is the chanted-sung narrative (called *khap*). A similar genre in regard to its sound pattern features is prayer. Aside from the purely aesthetic aspects, the poetic and musical features of this verbal art form have long been recognized for being especially memorable, in different ways. Hartmann (1984, pp. 74–8) summarizes the research from Northern Vietnam Tai-Lue communities. A notable feature of the song structure of the narratives, in addition to the patterns of alliteration and assonance throughout, is a linking internal rhyme that ties the final syllable of the phrase to the beginning syllables of the following phrase. The sound repetition gives the “sensation of weaving” Hartmann (1984, p. 78) that in addition accentuates a rhythmic patterning. The grammatical shift from one phrase to the next, in this interlocking way, introduces a pause (caesura) observed in other kinds of Tai chanted narrative. An interesting detail regarding the diffusion of the chanted-sung story is the geographical spread of the Tai-Lue communities themselves, from the north straddling the border with China through to Laos and four provinces of Thailand.

In regard to the above-mentioned national, Vietnamese-language, tradition, Balaban (2003) has documented a similar device of literary language in the recited poetry of rural communities, passed down in the oral tradition from one generation to the next by village poets. In the six–eight time *ca dao* genre, verses are linked by distributing “even” tones (on the

2nd, 6th, and 8th syllables) and “sharp” tones (on the 4th); rhyme falls on an “even” syllable. Couplets can then be spontaneously joined to create new, longer, poems.

The Bá Thuộc Tai Literary Study Group has focused attention on a number of historical texts of the song narrative type. This work is closely related to the recovery of original manuscripts that given their state of deterioration require copying, electronic preservation, and often translation. In addition, the difficult task of transliteration from documents written in *chữ nôm* (see Supporting Information 1) consumes significant resources. The epic narrative poems *Trường ca Ủ Thềm* and *Khăm Panh*, in the assessment of the study group, akin to *Tale of Kiều* in their poetic attributes, still require a final and definitive Tai-language edition and further scholarly investigation. The accounts of ancient dominions and the themes of cataclysm, legendary heroism, and personal sacrifice are the annals of a community today dispersed over a wide region. They are about events distant in time that form part of the community’s historical memory (see Đặng 2023; Lê and Lê 2021). A special feature of the chanted/sung epics is the use of paired verses in a responsorial style that also helps preserve the material in memory. The different kinds of sound repetition and the closely related aesthetic device of parallelism are the hallmarks of these verbal art forms.

4 | Results From the School Setting

4.1 | The Perspective of Families and Educators

Continuing with the summary of findings (from the January and February 2024 field study), interviews with parents, teachers, and school directors presented the following language ability cross-section that is consistent with the most recent official census.

Cảnh Nang: While 35% of households self-identified on the national survey as ethnically Muong, virtually all residents, adults and children, command full proficiency in Vietnamese. Given that Vietnamese and Muong are linguistically close, it is possible that many more than one-third of adults and children understand Muong to some degree.

Cổ Lũng: While over 99% of families indicate ethnic identification as Thái, advanced ability in Vietnamese, including literacy, among young and middle-aged adults also approximates, if not coincides completely with, the same language ability profile in Vietnamese of Cảnh Nang. Out of a population of 4115 in Cổ Lũng, 4105 self-identify as Thái (People’s Committee of Bá Thuộc District 2022).

Individual parent interviews ($N = 95$) also closely reflected the population–ethnic–language estimate for both localities. Conversations with parents and interaction centered on reading printed documents, and the responses in writing on permission forms confirmed the broad effect of national literacy campaign efforts of the last three decades. So far, the evidence suggests that adults, both men and women, under the age of 60, have attained full reading and writing ability and overall fluent proficiency in Vietnamese, to the same degree in rural Cổ Lũng village as in the more centric Cảnh Nang town. Table 2 summarizes the results of the parent interview from the majority Thái locality of Cổ Lũng.

Henceforth, the analysis of results will focus attention mainly on the fieldwork from this bilingual Thái-speaking village.

Historically, following independence, adult literacy, especially in the outlying provinces, was tied to improving the learning of Vietnamese as a second language, and then regularizing both objectives in all public schools, for children, where previously these objectives had not been consistently established. It is important to discuss the policy of a strong emphasis on reading and writing in the national language, in both the urban and the rural multicultural districts, within this broader social context. The newly independent nation had set a closely related nationwide language and literacy objective: that of completely replacing the former colonial language as a medium of instruction. In Vietnam, during the period of the 1950s onward, only one language could serve this objective in every school public school without exception (Trinh 2018; Ngô et al. 2024).

4.2 | Playground and Classroom Observation

A more systematic schema for observing this domain of language use needs to be implemented in future studies of the project. Nevertheless, on the surface, comparing the observations in the two localities helped to inform the tentative assessment results. While in Cảnh Nang the common language among children during recess time and dismissal is uniformly Vietnamese, by all indications, as predicted, in the elementary school playground, conversation in Cổ Lũng, in the first-grade cohort, is bilingual, favoring Thái, roughly slightly more than half of the time.

In comparison, a difference appears in Cổ Lũng, tentatively, subject to confirmation, among older children, graduating from the primary grades and entering middle school: a significant increase in Thái-language use in the playground (clearly predominant), observed by the first author, and confirmed on a separate occasion, from observations reported by school principals. This preliminary observation, coinciding with an informal observation of local educators, is subject to confirmation from a follow-up longitudinal study of language use patterns. In the classroom, only the Vietnamese language is typically used with the teacher, with one exception in the early grades in which the teacher reported explaining concepts from time to time in Thái. Conversation observed in class among first graders is mainly in Vietnamese, but not exclusively.

4.3 | Interview and Assessment With Children

Preliminary pilot testing of the *Bilingual Assessment of Child Language* (Vietnamese–Thái version) was undertaken during January and February of 2024 in the two localities of the Bá Thuộc district mentioned above. A full account, detailing the results of the evaluation of reliability and validity, awaits detailed analysis and confirmation. However, raw score group averages are available for reporting as these suggest preliminary tendencies that are final and cannot be altered.

The assessment consisted of three sub-sections: an introductory conversation organized around 6 questions (Greetings—12

TABLE 2 | Results of parent interview in Cổ Lũng ($N = 47$): Children's knowledge of Thái and Vietnamese and use of Thái and Vietnamese language at home.

1.	What languages does your child know?	For all 47 children, average	Thái:	100%	Vietnamese:	100%
2.	How often does your child speak	For all 47 children, average each language to you at home?	Thái:	43%	Vietnamese:	57%
3.	In what languages does your child speak	For all 47 children, average to relatives and neighbors?	Thái:	53%	Vietnamese:	47%
4.	In what languages do adults speak with each other at home?	Thái almost always:				87.2%
		Vietnamese almost always:				6.4%
		Thái & Vietnamese both:				6.4%

TABLE 3 | Results of the Greetings and Story Q&A sub-sections for versions in Vietnamese and Thái.

	Cảnh Nang ($N = 48$)	Cổ Lũng ($N = 47$)
Average total score (32 = 100%)—Vietnamese	31.8	31.9
Average total score (32 = 100%)—Thái	0.5	27.8
Number of children who attempted the Story Retelling section, immediately following the Story Q&A		
	Cảnh Nang ($N = 48$)	Cổ Lũng ($N = 47$)
Vietnamese	47/48	47/47
Thái	0/48	45/47

points), 10 questions based on a graphic display of five scenes corresponding to a short story, displayed pictorially (Story Q&A—20 points), and an independent narration of the same story to confirm comprehension of the questions of the Story Q&A. The three sub-sections were administered to the child twice: once for a Vietnamese-language version and (with a different, but parallel, story) once for a Thái-language version (see Supporting Information 2).

The following initial summation in Table 3 is relevant to an informal observation of Hà Nam Ninh, shared during his interview with Achariya (2022, 367), regarding a shift of language preference/usage by children toward Vietnamese, away from Thái.

First, note the line “Average total score (32 = 100%)-Thái.” The results of the Thái-language assessment in the Vietnamese-dominant community (Cảnh Nang) in which proficient, non-Thái, speakers of Vietnamese were selected, confirm that children cannot typically respond correctly by guessing from contextual clues.

One 1st grader from Cảnh Nang was able to guess responses for enough items on the Thái-language Q&A to attain a score of 10 (out of 32). The student subsequently explained to the researcher his strategy: (without any knowledge of the Thái language) he attended to each illustration during the Q&A and proceeded to describe, in Vietnamese, the action sequence in each of the five episodes. Three other children applied this method to garner 5, 4, and 3 points, respectively. Forty-four children from the

Vietnamese language-dominant community of Cảnh Nang did not attempt any response on either Greetings or Q&A of the Thái session.

Turning our attention to the Thái language-speaking village, the partial results from Cổ Lũng, specifically, do not unambiguously confirm nor contradict the observation of a language shift toward Vietnamese and away from Thái. Further study is necessary to verify or disconfirm the estimation, and then to examine the different broader tendencies of apparent preservation/stability versus language shift. What factors account for one tendency versus the other? On this point, it is important to reiterate that the observation of Hà Nam Ninh of a possible language shift in the child generation, generally across all Tai-speaking districts, remains an open question.

Readers will note that while the results from the Vietnamese section of the *Bilingual Assessment* suggest full command of the national language in both communities, the Thái-language section indicates the possibility of an imbalance to some degree or of some kind. As Table 3 shows, the first-grade children in the majority Thái community of Cổ Lũng attained:

- an average score of 31.9 (99.7%) in Vietnamese, and
- an average score of 27.8 (86.9%) in Thái.

Recall that the Cổ Lũng community is not only majority Thái but overwhelming so, in addition to being located in an exclusively rural region of demonstrably high ethnolinguistic vitality.³

Interviews with educators in Cổ Lũng and throughout the district provided context that might in the end contribute to a more complete interpretation of the data. In particular, what suggested the need to go back to the interview transcripts was a notable, if not unusual, pattern in the bilingual children's responses during the Thái-language Greetings and Q&A sub-sections, related to language switch or choice. First, during the Vietnamese session (Dog Story), there appeared no insertion or codeswitch to Thái in any of the language samples, neither in the Greetings nor Q&A. Conversely, in the Thái session (Chicken Story), insertion and switching to Vietnamese was prolific. The scoring procedure for language choice (mixing in general or entire responses in the opposite language) in child responses was the following:

- Mixed-language sentences or phrases, regardless of which language is the matrix or predominant language, receive the same score as if the response was unilingual in the expected language (in most cases full credit of *two points*). Due to the parallels in morphology and syntax patterns between Vietnamese and Thái, mixing itself never or almost never alters grammatical well-formedness in short-answer Q&A formats as in the example of the present assessment. See Suriya (2007) for a summary of the relevant linguistic comparisons regarding the sustained language contact among the languages of the region.
- If the child's response is entirely in Vietnamese during the Thái session (opposite language responses never occurred during the application of the Vietnamese session), and after the interviewer requests that the answer be given in Thái, for a meaningful response that shows an understanding of the question, a score of *one point* is assigned.

In regard to the second scoring option, upon inspection of the distribution of scores (0, 1, 2), it was observed that the vast majority, over 90%, of items that received 1 point were not for a response that reflected incomplete comprehension nor a poorly formulated answer but for responding entirely in Vietnamese after the request: "could you say it in Thái."⁴

Score intervals⁵ indicate the proposed levels:

○ native-speaker	29–32
○ near-native	26–28
○ advanced L2 learner	23–25
○ intermediate L2 learner	16–22
○ beginner	3–15
○ entry-level 0	0–2

On the Thái section in Cổ Lũng, of the 47 first-grade children, 74.5% attained a level of native or near-native, and none scored within the intervals of "beginner" or "entry-level 0."

Next, project investigators asked the question regarding the overall impact of awarding *one point* for the Vietnamese response in the Thái session. Recall that the converse did not present itself in the Vietnamese session for any child response. Hypothetically rescoring the groups "intermediate L2 learner" ($N = 5$), "advanced L2 learner" ($N = 7$), and "near-native" ($N = 10$), *not discounting*

the one point for exclusively Vietnamese-language response, all children except for one would then fall within the "native-speaker" range of 29–32. To reiterate, the partial credit, *one point* score, was assigned in the Thái session to Vietnamese-language responses that were acceptable from the point of view of meaning, and hypothetically giving them full credit, *two points*, presents a hypothetical profile of 46 "native-speaker" (29–32) and 1 "advanced L2 learner" (23–25).

During interviews, teachers and principals in the Thái-speaking region of Cổ Lũng, the majority of whom are bilingual, described the local sociolinguistic context and changes in school language policy that have a bearing on this section of the assessment results. Two alternative explanations can be presented:

- (1) The performance of the "intermediate L2 learner—advanced L2 learner—near-native" group points to an actual emergence of Vietnamese as the dominant language among a subset of the 6-year-old population. Of all first-grade children, at least 46 of 47 possess full listening ability in Thái. Of these: 25 children retain native speaking ability, 10 retain near-native speaking ability, and 12 approach the category of so-called "receptive bilingual" (Nakamura 2019).
- (2) The situational context of school, in a classroom, during an assessment with a teacher, known to all the children as bilingual, inhibits expression in Thái among children, affecting the performance of almost half to some degree. Actual knowledge of Thái has not declined, the results mainly reflecting language use/preference, related to context. Thus, anticipated and unanticipated "external influences" may have skewed children's language choices during the Thái Q&A, giving the *impression* of an imbalance in ability.

Describing the apparent imbalance and eventually proposing an explanation is important in light of the above-mentioned observation (from Section 4.2) of a potentially measurable increase in Thái language use in sixth grade, in comparison to first grade. A degree of agreement among adult participants exists on the informal observation that by the end of primary school children appear to "recover" predominant-universal Thái language use in community domains and at school in the playground, after a period of preferential use of Vietnamese during kindergarten and 1st grade. If correct, this account would lend tentative support to the (situational context) hypothesis #2 above.

Interview participants (adults) described the following scenario. A new language learning approach for the Cổ Lũng elementary school was adopted beginning in the 2000s to boost preschool children's Vietnamese language proficiency. The new policy came at the end of a series of language education reforms and national initiatives beginning with the 1945–1952 literacy campaign, followed up by the campaign of 1961–1965. The new focus on language education and literacy placed emphasis on second-language learning of Vietnamese in the Thái-speaking region as well as for second-language learners of Vietnamese across all provinces.

Perhaps as a result, by the early 1990s, parents began shifting toward bilingualism at home, a greater use of Vietnamese in

everyday conversation, according to participants. Recall the observation above from Section 4.1 that all interviewed parents, without exception, demonstrated advanced levels of both literacy and spoken-language ability in Vietnamese, in addition to having preserved full speaking ability in Thái.

Returning to the new learning approach of 2000, with the support of parents, the preschool program, that begins 3 years prior to 1st grade—2 years plus kindergarten, the third year called *lớp lớn* (“big class”)—began to affirmatively emphasize speaking Vietnamese, preferably so. Kindergarten and 1st grade culminate the Vietnamese-language emphasis with systematic encouragement and incentive to speak Vietnamese in school. Needless to say, models of second language learning of this type are the topic of ongoing discussion and controversy (Ha and Tran 2017; Tran 2021; Tran et al. 2023; Vu 2014).

For now, considering all of the partial evidence above, neither explanation (1) nor (2) for the imbalance in switching to Vietnamese during the assessment can yet be discarded in favor of the other, allowing alternatively the acceptance of one or the other applied to the circumstances of each individual case. Another important finding suggests to us that neither explanation (1) nor (2) should be favored at this time. Detailed examination of each Thái-Vietnamese mixed reply during the Thái language session (Chicken Story) showed unequivocally that none of the mixed sentences or phrases resulted in an ungrammatical sequence. This result suggests that exposure to Vietnamese learning during the preschool years has not affected the well-formedness of bilingual speech constituents. This suggestion now presents the consideration of further study, including longitudinal assessment, on the relationship between indices of language competence and actual language use. As seems plausible, the changes over the years associated with the tendency toward a greater centering of the national language during the pre-school years appear for now as compatible with both explanations (1) and (2). Future research will be able to focus attention on this question more sharply.

5 | Discussion and Conclusion

What are the prospects for bilingual communities that have concluded the transition to acceptance of the national language not only in its use for teaching literacy in school but also as a second language of universal mastery among children and young adults (<60)? How can communities avail themselves of the relevant cultural knowledge and orientation that contributes to sustaining stable bilingualism (Wang 2024; Watson 2020)? Returning to the concept of awareness from Section 1, deliberate reflection on (ongoing awareness of) aspects of *language knowledge-language use* and *cultural knowledge-cultural practices* appears as the central contributing factor of sustainability in these domains. The initial round of interviews, observations, and assessments, as summarized briefly in Section 4, has pointed to a potential access to linguistic and cultural resources along the two dimensions introduced in Section 1.

Relationship—across space (the “horizontal” dimension), inter-connection among communities: The geographic scope of the Tai language branch incorporates speakers from near (across

the international border) and far (from Guanxi to Bangkok). As the example of the Tai-Lue from Section 3.3 suggests, maximal dispersion of the language does not necessarily entail loss of mutual comprehensibility and ongoing contact.

Continuity—across time (“vertical” dimension) in regard to a common literary inheritance: The existence of a corpus of conserved historical documents in the possession of households throughout the greater northern region and the preservation of an oral tradition. The results of the work of the Bá Thước Literary Study Group attest to the importance of this inheritance. A deep heritage of traditional narrative and poetry becomes the archival material for community-based preservation and research, a topic that needs to be deferred for another occasion.

For this study, for now, the result of the imbalance in bilingual speech (switching/mixing only attested during the Thái-language session), while it is suggestive of the beginnings of a shift toward Vietnamese in the child generation, cannot yet be presented as evidence of such a shift:

- because we cannot discount the effect on performance of the contextual and cultural factors, and
- for the consistent pattern observed of a very high level of grammaticality of mixed Thái-Vietnamese sentences and phrases.⁶

The important idea in the discussion of these resources (that also implies in this case that the proposal is controversial) is that not all bilingual communities are able to avail themselves of them, because of historical circumstances, to the same degree. In this respect, Tai in Vietnam is perhaps an exceptional case, a possibility that was proposed in the Abstract. This hypothesis follows from the partial results of the study in Bá Thước district. If, in the end, the child assessment data reflect a stable bilingualism, this outcome would be consistent with the preservation of traditional poetic and narrative genres in the adult population. The extent to which this relationship might apply to other Tai-speaking communities of the region is a question for continuing field study.

While a given variant of Tai may be termed a “minority” language, the term is misleading, as the previous discussion has suggested, because speakers of the language, for example, another dialect of it, reside in another region, often in close proximity (e.g., in Laos where it is “majority”). A Tai community in one region may begin to undergo a language shift, but the situation of the language itself, concentrated perhaps in another region of Vietnam, and across the international border, remains stable. This kind of distribution might apply to other “minority” languages of Vietnam.

Along another axis, school language policy in bilingual communities will continue to be central to the research program regarding first and second-language learning. No part of the presentation of data in Section 4 should be taken as an attempt to minimize the importance of planning questions that affect minority languages. The debate in Vietnam on the different alternative program models for child second language learners and bilingual speakers is complex and ongoing (Vu 2020). Again, this last observation

should not be taken as a suggestion to postpone the discussion on language policy in education. One concluding recommendation, however, that the present study is making for this discussion is that direct assessment of bilingual ability, of the kind presented in Sections 2 and 4, is a necessary part of an informed exchange of views.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

Peer Review

The peer review history for this article is available at <https://publons.com/publon/10.1111/ijal.12719>.

Endnotes

¹ The Tai-speaking communities of Vietnam form part of a larger Tai language family, some of which are sufficiently close linguistically to allow for degrees of inter-communication, and others which are distant linguistically, and do not. The family extends over a vast geographical area from Yunnan and Guangxi Provinces in China south through Vietnam, to Laos and Thailand where the local variants are the national/official language, and then to communities in Myanmar, Cambodia, and India. Readers will encounter variation in naming, for example different names for the same speech-community residing on both sides of an international border, or in different provinces and districts. The Tai family of languages forms part of a larger language branch, Kra-Dai (or Tai-Kadai), separate from the neighboring Sino-Tibetan, Austroasiatic and Hmong-Mien families (Edmondson and Gregerson 2007). Speakers of languages from the three language families are often close neighbors, from within the same or adjoining village.

² A note on spelling: “Tai” refers to the branch or family of Tai languages or often to a language that is a member of this branch or family. In Vietnam, the official spelling of the local variant of the Tai family spoken in northern Thanh Hóa province is “Thái.”

³ The results of the assessment reported here for the first time are from a pilot reliability-validity test of the assessment instrument. Even taking into consideration this narrow purpose, the appearance of a possible imbalance between the Vietnamese and Thái sections requires comment in the current paper because a plausible explanation speaks directly to the participation of a contextual, sociolinguistic/education policy, factor.

⁴ Scoring guide for Greetings and Q&A for the Thái session:
2 points (full credit)—a meaningful response that shows the child understood the question. The response can be either all Thái or Thái with switching to Vietnamese.
1 point—an incomplete answer, or a meaningful or incomplete answer all in Vietnamese after the teacher asks: “could you say it in Thái.”
0 points—a response, in either language, that shows that the child did not understand the question.

⁵ The preliminary score ranges (for native-speaker, near-native-speaker, advanced second language learner, etc.) are adapted from the *Bilingual Syntax Measure* (Burt et al. 1980). The essential feature of the BSM that we adopted was in reference to the category of “advanced L2 learner,” coinciding with level 3 (out of 5) on the BSM. Crucially, on the BSM, a score of 3 in *both languages* of the bilingual child suggests a recommendation for follow-up assessment for possible language impairment. In other words, all children in the present Thái-Vietnamese

study, *not diagnosed with a language impairment*, were expected to score either in the 4 or 5 point range in at least one of their languages. Tentatively, all indications are that this result has been attained in both communities, Cánh Nang and Cổ Lũng ($N = 95$).

⁶ In response to a question from an anonymous reviewer: All households in Cổ Lũng receive national programming on television and/or internet, which of course broadcast exclusively in the national language.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section.